is this cultural veneration and a sense of relational custodianship, to put it in the language of decoloniality, as opposed to a sense of territorial ownership, that has made it possible for Bharat to be a melting pot of diverse sects that have coexisted *within* the Dharmic fold. This is precisely what separates the Indic civilisational worldview from those that drive Middle Eastern and European colonialities, which are founded on the firm belief of domination or annihilation of identities that do not conform to their own, and that they have been divinely ordained to expand territorially in the service of their respective belief systems.

As long as this divergence and incompatibility remain, Indic civilisational consciousness has no option but to approach both colonialities with a sense of justified circumspection and vigilance given their respective histories in Bharat and in the rest of the world. In fact, I would go to the extent of stating that since Bharat is the only natural homeland for the Indic consciousness, the Indian State has the civilisational duty to ensure that this space remains as such, and the accommodation of any other consciousness is contingent on (*a*) respect for the undeniable and inseparable relationship between Bharat and the Indic consciousness and (*b*) giving up those tenets that dehumanise the Indic consciousness or call for its extermination, whether scripturally sanctioned or not.

Second, inherent in the treatment of Bharat as a cultural possession as opposed to a material one is the respect for, nay deification of its geographical features. The retention of this relational land ontology as part of Bharat's mindset is critical for the preservation of its indigenous consciousness. This affects its political approach to its geography and borders as much as it affects its approach to what constitutes 'development'. This would translate to the principle that no part of this sacred geography must be tested solely on the anvils of its utility as a natural resource. To this culturally rooted perspective, it does not make a difference whether 'even a blade of grass' grows or not, or whether a particular part of this geography is 'useless uninhabitable land'. That such words were used by the first prime minister of Bharat, Jawaharlal Nehru, in 1962 to describe a part of this sacred geography, and that too in the backdrop of Chinese aggression, is a reflection of how far removed Bharat was even in 1962 from its cultural spirit of veneration and deification of all parts of its geography to instead employ a cold, downright utilitarian and territorial approach. In my opinion, that every inch of this land is sacred and its sanctity is inviolable is a greater